

DA RULES

12 rules for drawing out in the world!

OF URBAN SKETCHING

the numbers show where each rule happens



(1) SIT STILL LONG ENOUGH TO OBSERVE.

Watch for 2 whole minutes before your first line.

(2) LOOK FOR A "STORY MOMENT."

What stands out? That's your subject.

(3) START W/ LARGE SHAPES! NO DETAIL.

Story moment first: **big**, in the middle. Then build out.

(4) DRAW PEOPLE AS GESTURES, NOT PORTRAITS.

Bean body, stick limbs. Show what they're **doing**.

(5) USE LINE WEIGHT TO FAKE DEPTH.

Close = thick + dark.
Far = thin + light.

(6) BREAK PERSPECTIVE RULES

(strategically!) Lean it or bend it if it tells the story.

(7) LEAVE STUFF OUT.

Not every brick, board or leaf. Let the edges fade away.

(8) DON'T ERASE!

Pen from line one. No pencil = nothing to erase.

(11)
Sat · 10:42 am
smells like orange blossoms
bees everywhere!

(9) TREAT MISTAKES LIKE THEY BELONG.

Wrong line? Draw the right one next to it.

(10) EMBRACE SPEED.

Fast lines look alive. Don't fuss.

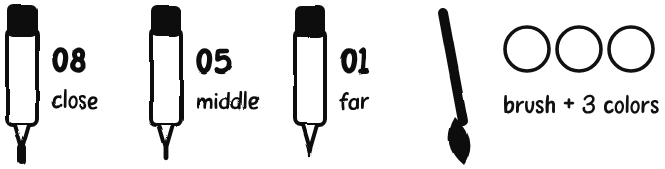
(11) ADD NOTES OR TINY TEXT.

The time, the place, what you smelled.

(12) LIMITED COLOR POPS.

Ink first. Then 2-3 colors, only where it matters.

YOUR KIT:  **no pencil!**



INK, WAIT, PAINT. Microns are waterproof once they dry. Give the ink a minute, then add your color pops with watercolor.

How to build a sketch from the

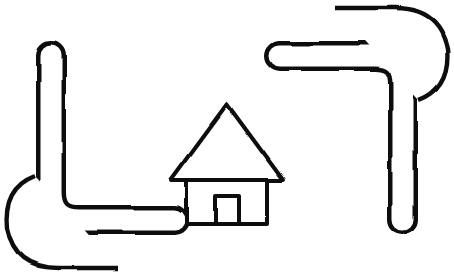
CENTER OUT

Don't draw the whole place! Find the **one thing that stands out**, draw it big in the middle of your page, then let the world grow out around it.

STORY MOMENT HUNT!

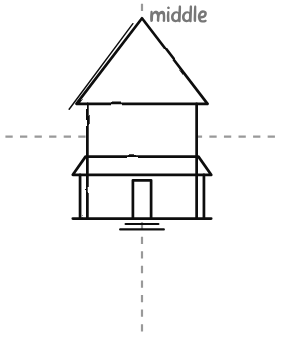
Look around for one of these... (or find your own)

- **Someone waiting**
- **Someone working**
- **A dog on a mission**
- **A door left open**
- **An old house with a story**
- **Something being picked**
- **Two people talking**
- **A tree doing something weird**



frame it with your fingers

Size check: your story moment should be about the size of your **fist** on the page. Smaller than that? **Start over bigger.**







1ST: THE STORY MOMENT.

Big shapes only, in the middle. Thick lines.

2ND: PARTS + NEIGHBORS.

Windows, posts, whatever is touching it.

3RD: THE SETTING.

Thin lines going out. Let the edges fade.

4TH: COLOR POPS + NOTES.

2-3 colors, tiny text, sign it!



Notice how step 1 has nothing else yet. That's on purpose. Get the moment right and the rest is easy.

YOUR TIME:

Look 3 min · Ink 20 min
Color 10 min · Notes 2 min

WATERCOLOR POPS, IN 3 MOVES

1. Let the ink dry. Count to 60.
2. One big, light wash first. Lots of water.
3. One bold pop last. Leave some paper white!

KEEP SKETCHING!

Fill a page a week. Try your **lunch table**, your **street** from the curb, or a **waiting room** (everyone sits still: free models!). Same rules: find the moment, start big, build out.